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Original Page: 171**Culture (OWC):** [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Eastern Africa**Field Date:** 1954-1957**Coverage Date:** 1930-1957**Place Coverage**

Community of Nyansongo, South Nyanza District, Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): Chapter 15 The Initiation Of Girls

Although the atmosphere is one of almost frantic hilarity, the women indulge in insulting, fighting, and destructive behavior which would ordinarily be taboo. For example, one middle-aged woman said to another, "You uncircumcised girl, what keeps you in the house when we take girls for circumcision? Is it your husband who keeps you?" The epithet and joking reference to marital coitus would be insulting in everyday social intercourse. Mention has been made of the young women beating each other with sticks; friendly tussling was also observed. Most striking is the wanton theft and destruction of crops. When the women accompanying her daughter arrived at Bosibori's house, they pulled up more than half of her potato garden, gorging themselves on raw potatoes and taking others with them. She became furious and tried to stop them, but they said, "This is a happy occasion; we can do anything, even annoy you." Three older women tied all the potato shoots into bundles and carried them away to plant in their own gardens. The group also trampled all the unripe maize in a small field near the house. At the houses of other women whose daughters had just been operated on, accompanying neighbors grabbed numerous ears of ripe corn from their fields. This license is expected, and [172](#) even when carried to excess, as at Bosibori's, it is not recognized as ground for legal action or any other kind of retribution.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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